



Young Turk: At 16, Shabnam Shakil was the youngest debutant in the WPL when she took the field for Gujarat Giants against Royal Challengers Bangalore. R. V. MOORTHY

surfaces used there were low and slow, with barely any bounce but plenty of turn on the odd night. Batters who learned to stay down and play to the conditions found a way to hit back, while others found themselves with their stumps in disarray. The testing conditions in Delhi also produced a final week with back-to-back nail-biting finishes, and the team that took that challenge in stride — Royal Challengers Bangalore — ultimately finished with its name inscribed on the trophy.

Multiple pitches used at the same venue meant having a much shorter boundary on some nights, which sometimes made the game a bit lopsided in the batter's favour, especially if they were left-handed. Lanning called for bigger boundaries. "It is a nightmare to have a 40m boundary on one side. That is one thing I haven't necessarily enjoyed as a captain. We could look at potentially having slightly bigger boundaries. If it is even all the way around, that makes sense. But

there's so much more power in the game now that people are clearing the ropes easily. I have lost a lot of sleep over games where there's only a 40m boundary on one side, especially when there's left-handers like Smriti," she stated before the final.

The franchises are constantly striving to maximise their presence in the cricket ecosystem from a business standpoint. Although the Board of Control for Cricket in India centrally manages the venues, it has allowed two franchises, RCB and DC, to attract home fans. The support from Bengaluru's crowd was unparalleled, and even in Delhi, the average spectator was often an RCB fan wearing different colours. It helps that the team's biggest male star, Virat Kohli, hails from the city. The tournament also provided an opportunity for fans to get to know the female players better.

"Our biggest star is Meg Lanning. Her achievements and resume speak for themselves. Shafali Verma and Jemimah Rodrigues — these are all very popular personalities; We've seen Jemimah's engagement numbers on social media are better than most of her male counterparts. They are all important to the brand of Delhi Capitals," Divyanshu Singh,



MVP: Deepti Sharma unlocked her power-hitting potential, finishing with the Most Valuable Player Award for scoring 295 runs and taking 10 wickets. R. V. MOORTHY

COO - JSW Sports, told *Sportstar*.

Brand activations were key to WPL franchises this time around. UP Warriorz forged key partnerships with successful commercial and social entities, including Kay Beauty (run by Katrina Kaif), UN Women's 'Generation Equality Ally' drive, and others. Sanjay Adesara, CBO of Adani Sportsline, which owns Gujarat Giants, believes this trajectory is natural.

"Four to five years ago, there were only a couple of names we were familiar with in the sport. Today, not just the Indian team but so many foreign players have become household names here. It's natural to maximise that on and off the field," he told this publication.